Polymerized Dreams

Contents

[English text unavailable] 2
[English text unavailable] 2

[English text unavailable]

COL-2038522

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Vertin: [English text unavailable]

Vertin: [English text unavailable]

X: [English text unavailable]

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X: [English text unavailable]

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Mesmer Jr.: [English text unavailable]

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Vertin: [English text unavailable]

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Mesmer Jr.: [English text unavailable]

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X: [English text unavailable]

Mesmer Jr.: [English text unavailable]

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COL-2038523

Tereshkova: You have finished Exhibit A. But don't stop now, dear comrades.

Tereshkova: Please proceed to the lecture hall, where Dr. Sechenov will soon personally demonstrate the power of Kollektiv 2.0.

The young visitors are swept up in a rising commotion of people moving into a nearby lecture hall. There at the center of the crowd is Dr. Sechenov, standing above them at a podium.

Lecture Room, Polymer Exhibition Hall

Many scientists are already seated, talking amongst themselves about the exhibits. The young visitors shuffle into the back row.

Mesmer Jr.: Huh? Is that Maxim?

As Mesmer Jr. turns to get a better look, she sees a stern man in a suit and tie enter the hall.

When Dr. Sechenov spots the new arrival, he gives the man a pleasant, yet confident, welcome.

Behind the two men, Maxim raises his camera and presses the shutter button. Snap, snap, snap. The camera fires off a series of flashes.

Sechenov: I must thank you for coming, Comrade Molotov.

Molotov: Today is an important day for the Soviet Union. I wouldn't miss it, Comrade Sechenov.

Sechenov and Molotov shake hands to a flurry of flashing lights as journalists rush to capture the moment.

Scientist III: Molotov's here? It's hard to believe after all the bad blood between them.

The meeting between the two men causes an immediate ripple in the crowd. Sechenov returns to the podium to face a frothing sea of whispers.

He raises his hand toward the audience, and little by little, the rippling settles.

Sechenov: Thank you. First off, I'm very honored to have so many preeminent experts from every scientific field in attendance today. Welcome, everyone. I am Doctor Dmitry Sergeyevich Sechenov.

Sechenov: We all understand that there are times when a single discovery can turn the entire scientific world upside down.

Sechenov: But every great discovery must be built upon the knowledge of countless predecessors that rests at its foundation, to say nothing of luck, before it can be published and preserved for all time.

Sechenov: My achievements have never been solely my own. Only by standing on the shoulders of our forefathers have I gotten the chance to gaze upon the limitless horizons of science.

Sechenov: Standing here now, I must thank them from the bottom of my heart. Thank you. Thank you.

The audience breaks into roaring applause.

Sechenov: Nineteen years ago, when my team and I invented polymer, I had already foreseen its boundless potential.

Sechenov: A perfect synergy of mathematics, logic, physics, chemistry, biology, and other foundational studies in equal part, constantly pushing the frontiers of humanity's scientific exploration—

Sechenov: —bringing us to this historic day, where I have the honor of inviting every one of you to participate in this preview of Kollektiv 2.0.

Sechenov: Comrades, please follow me into the bright, limitless future!

The audience stirs as small metal platforms emerge from their seats. As they reach their intended positions, each platform opens to reveal a golden hemispherical device.

Mesmer Jr.: Hm? What's this?

X: THOUGHT Device.

Mesmer Jr. picks up and examines the object.

Mesmer Jr.: Hmm. A metallic outer shell with a silicon motherboard connected to swirling black tendril-like receptors.

She turns it over.

Mesmer Jr.: There are suction cups on its base.

Mesmer Jr. looks around. Quite a few scientists have already attached these devices to their temples. The tendril-like receptors begin to wriggle above their foreheads.

She watches for the crowd's reaction before gently prodding the suction cups with her finger.

Vertin: They've all put it on without any hesitation.

Mesmer Jr.: No adverse reactions either. Looks like it doesn't hurt.

They continue watching the other scientists only to realize X has already stuck his device to his temple.

X: Hypothesis confirmed. Mounting the device does nothing to activate it alone.

The unresponsive THOUGHT Device falls into his hand.

X: Hmm. Counter-hypothesis. It may only work on polymerized people.

Mesmer Jr.: Wait! What are you doing?!

X injects himself with a syringe of clear liquid.

X: It makes sense. If the Plague was ended by mass polymerization, most of the attendees here would already have polymer in their system.

X: But we don't.

Mesmer Jr.: You injected yourself with that Redemption vaccine? Where did you even get that?!

X: The exhibition hall's got samples of everything, and I've always had a knack for collecting odds and ends.

Mesmer Jr.: But why would you inject yourself?

X: During our last experiment, I kept thinking that we were missing something. But now, I've finally figured it out.

X: We don't belong in this world. Even if we change our appearances, at our core, we're still outsiders. But perhaps by injecting myself, I can truly become an influencing factor in this world.

X: What sort of chain reaction will this set off? I'm excited to find out.

X opens his hand, revealing two more syringes of polymer.

X: Plus, if we don't inject ourselves, we risk exposing our identities.

X: Of course, the choice is yours.

Mesmer Jr.: I should've expected this. Typical arcanist behavior.

Mesmer Jr.: Why don't I just hold onto these potentially dangerous substances for now? Please try to exercise a little more caution in the future, "Dr. X."

As the vigilant researcher stows the remaining syringes in her coat pocket, her mischievous colleague shrugs.

X: What about you, Vertin?

Vertin: I think we should be careful.

X: Alright, but think about all the fun you could be missing out on.

He raises the THOUGHT Device to his head, and it suctions itself onto his temple. The black tendrils begin wiggling in even waves above his forehead.

X: Oh! Fascinating. It's like a whole new perspective. This demands thorough exploration.

Sechenov: Comrades, I encourage you all to try these THOUGHT Devices and experience a preview of Kollektiv 2.0's features!

Maxim: Dr. Sechenov! Please allow me a question!

Maxim: Kollektiv 1.0 has already saved our citizens from a disaster, but now you're aggressively pushing—pardon my wording—for the launch of Kollektiv 2.0.

Maxim: Do you intend to have the entire population wired to these THOUGHT Devices? How can you ensure the devices are safe?

Maxim: Are you not concerned about the potential dangers? What if this new Kollektiv fails in some way and threatens all our hard-won happiness?

Maxim: I only mean to say that so many people gave their lives to help us get this far. I wouldn't wanna see their sacrifices rendered meaningless.

Sechenov: I do understand your fear, comrade, but please rest assured: we've conducted rigorous testing and verified that the THOUGHT Device is completely safe.

Sechenov: With that reassurance, I ask that once you've implanted your THOUGHT Device, you please continue to the next gallery, where you'll be able to experience the wonders of mind-machine interface in a live demonstration.

Sechenov: I thank you all again for your participation, and I look forward to exploring this new horizon with you all!

As he ends his speech, Molotov stands up to leave, and Maxim chases after him.

Sechenov busies himself in a round of handshakes and introductions as he steps down from the stage and makes his way past the audience. The Twins follow close behind him.

Vertin: ...

Sechenov: Oh! I remember you!

Sechenov: You weren't hurt, were you? Tereshkova wasn't able to properly handle the crowd. I've already arranged for staff to work on improving her logic.

Vertin: I'm fine, Dr. Sechenov. Your Twins helped me up.

Vertin: They seem somewhat different from other robots.

Sechenov: You have a sharp eye, dear girl. When I constructed the Twins, I made use of some experimental techniques—currently impossible to mass-produce, I'm afraid.

The robot assistants stand waiting for Dr. Sechenov's command, their sleek, powerful frames silent, yet passively imposing.

Sechenov: The epitome of both science and art, a perfect fusion of power and beauty—I think of them as my greatest creation.

Vertin: They do have a rather reassuring presence.

Sechenov smiles with a nod before changing the topic back to the visitors.

Sechenov: I heard there'd be three young scientists joining us today. To be so accomplished at such a young age is something worthy of respect.

Sechenov: If you run into any trouble today, please don't hesitate to tell me. I'll do whatever I can to assist you.

X: Oh, as it happens. I think we actually could use some help.

X pulls out the broken communicator.

X: Do you have any idea where we could get this device fixed?